ANCE



of India facility at Sonipat, Antil has been working with coach Arun Kumar for the past year, fine-tuning his technique while making the most of his explosive strength that he developed during his younger days as a wrestler. Sport was always a means to a livelihood while growing up in Khewra in Sonipat, Haryana, but over time, Antil's dreams have changed, just like his targets.

"When I started competing, the world record was around the 59m mark. People would say things like, oh, you manage to win medals by throwing such small distances. That pinched me and got stuck in the head. I decided to take para sports to a different level, so that no para athlete has to hear these things," he says.

Antil believes a lot has changed over the past few years when it comes to para sports. For one, he has observed more spectators in stadiums around the world and he hopes to see the same back home in India. "For any sport to pick up, it needs a moment of magic—like winning the World Cup for cricket or Neerajbhai's (Neeraj Chopra's) Olympic gold for javelin throw. Para sports in India, too, needs something big to get people to sit up and take notice," he says.

That could happen if Antil is able to attain his dream of making the 80m mark in the time ahead. With his penchant for chasing records and the World Para Athletics Championships and the Paris Paralympics next year, that moment couldn't be very far either. ■



Shail Desai

BOOKS

Play, the Beloved Country

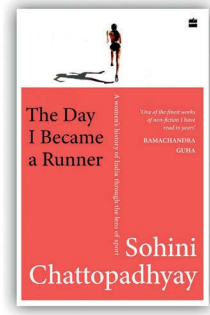
In addressing the gender inequality plaguing Indian sport, this book by **Sohini Chattopadhyay** does not mince any words

This stunningly original book can be read in many ways: as stories of India's finest women athletes, as a commentary on all that is wrong with Indian sport, as a cry for sensitive handling of sex and gender issues, as a treatise on patriarchy and its pernicious influence, as a challenge to such patriarchy, and, as the subtitle suggests, *A Women's History of India Through the Lens of Sport*. It is a rewarding experience, even if it does force us to hang our heads in shame at various points.

Our international wrestlers protesting the behaviour of an official is merely the most recent of India's continuing battle against male entitlement. It has ever been thus, whether you are an international sportswoman or a 'hobby runner', like the author. "The 2020s feel a lot like the 1940s," writes the author, and you realise this is not a sports book so much as "the arc of citizenship of women in the Indian republic". Personal stories are woven in, creating a tapestry at once colourful and subtle.

India's significant women athletes are all here, from Mary D'Souza, the first Olympian (1952), through P.T. Usha to Dutee Chand, who has come out publicly as gay.

The most powerful (and heartbreaking) accounts are those of Santhi Soundarajan, Pinki Pramanik and Dutee Chand, who had to undergo untold humiliation for "not being female enough". In time, even the International Olympic Committee has come to realise there is no one parameter that makes a person biologically male or female. As Chattopadhyay points out, there may be 38 variations on the spectrum.



THE DAY I BECAME A RUNNER
A women's history of India through the lens of sport
by Sohini Chattopadhyay
FOURTH ESTATE
₹599; 364 pages

The narrative loops back to the 1940s and the story of Ila Mitra, later a politician and activist, who was perhaps "the first woman in the subcontinent to publicly articulate the experience of rape".

These unique stories of successful athletes from different decades and backgrounds are, however, eerily similar. The strength of this well-researched and beautifully written book lies as much in its subject matter as in the handling of it. It highlights issues seldom raised in India and puts them in a historical context.

The individual narratives foreground the big picture, and heroes—parents, coaches, friends, neighbours—emerge. As do villains. "When you are broken you run," wrote Helen McDonald, in *H Is for Hawk*. The reverse seems to be the case in India. When you run, you are broken.

The woman's body, says the author, is the site of conflict. "Both foeticide and acid attacks are crimes of erasure. Both seek to cancel the existence of women," she writes. She makes no effort to sugarcoat the bitter experiences our athletes go through, thanks to unfeeling officialdom and an unsympathetic public. The media isn't spared either.

Yet, for all that, the book deals in hope, just as the athletes themselves did. And this is its greatest triumph—sport is about optimism and renewal. For its bringing together of sport and nationhood, *The Day I Became a Runner* stands alone. It's a wakeup call. ■

Suresh Menon